CHEAP FAMILY DINNERS WITH THE COST PER SERVING (AND HOW TO WORK IT OUT) | TRILLION MAN OUTREACH WHAT'S FOR EATS | PRINTABLE DINNER GUIDE

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Easy Weeknight Dinner Recipes

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By the Trillion Man Outreach kitchen crew Updated October 8, 2026

Most lists of cheap dinners say budget-friendly and never show a number. This guide does the opposite. You will learn the simple math for cost per serving, see it worked out on real example meals and pick up habits that lower your grocery bill without making dinner sad.

The cost-per-serving formula

Cost per serving = total cost of the ingredients you used, divided by servings.
That is it. Use the price you actually paid, and only count the portion you used. A $3 bag of rice used for a quarter of the bag costs you about 75 cents, not $3.

Try it with our free
cost-per-serving calculator
.

Example: pantry pasta with white beans and spinach

These prices are illustrative. Yours will differ by store, region and month.

12 oz pasta: $1.50

24 oz jar marinara: $2.50

15 oz can white beans: $1.00

Spinach (frozen, partial bag): $1.00

Parmesan (small amount): $0.50

Total: $6.50. Divided by 4 servings is about
$1.63 per serving
. Swap in your own prices to see your real number. The recipe is in the
budget dinners section
.

Example: egg fried rice

Using illustrative prices of $1.00 for the rice used, $1.50 for four eggs, $1.00 for frozen vegetables, $0.40 for soy sauce and oil, the total is $3.90. Over 4 servings that

is about
$0.98 per serving
.

Seven ways to lower the number

Stretch protein.
Add beans, lentils or eggs to meat dishes.

Buy staples in larger bags
and portion them at home.

Use frozen vegetables.
They cost less, cook fast and do not spoil.

Plan around sales,
not the other way around.

Cook once, eat twice.
Leftovers lower your cost per meal. See
leftover chicken recipes
.

Keep a short pantry list.
Our
pantry staples list
covers the essentials.

Freeze extras
so food does not get wasted. See
freezer meals
.

Cheap does not have to mean boring

Flavor is cheap. Garlic, onion, lemon, spices and a bit of cheese on top change a meal more than an expensive cut of meat. For general healthy-eating-on-a-budget guidance, see USDA MyPlate
.

Want it done for you?

The
Cheap Dinner Vault
has 25 family dinners with the cost per serving worked out, cost tracker sheets and the pricing method, so you can see what dinner costs before you cook.

Let us take dinner off your plate

The Rescue Kit picks dinner by how tired you are. The Cheap Dinner Vault shows what each dinner costs.

Get the Rescue Kit

Get the Cheap Dinner Vault

Questions, answered

How do I calculate the cost per serving of a meal?

Add up the cost of the ingredients you actually used, then divide by the number of servings it makes.

What are the cheapest ingredients for family dinners?

Rice, pasta, dried or canned beans, eggs, frozen vegetables, canned tomatoes, onions and potatoes are the usual budget staples.

Explore every dinner guide

Keep building your weeknight plan with these related guides. Each one covers a different part of getting dinner on the table.

5-Ingredient Dinners: Short Grocery List, Real Dinner

Simple dinners with five ingredients or fewer.

Easy Dinner Ideas for When You Have No Energy

Low-effort ideas for exhausted nights.

Easy Sheet-Pan Dinners

One-pan dinner formulas, roasting tips and easy combinations.

Freezer Meals for Busy Weeknights

Make-ahead dinner ideas, freezing tips and safe thawing guidance.

Leftover Chicken Recipes

Turn leftover chicken into several easy dinners.

Pantry Staples List for Budget Cooking

Build a practical pantry for affordable meals and less food waste.

Picky-Eater Dinner Ideas That the Whole Table Will Eat

Low-pressure family dinner ideas and practical strategies.

Slow Cooker Dinners for Busy Families

Hands-off slow cooker meals, timing tips and safe food handling.

Weekly Meal Plan for Busy Families

A seven-night dinner plan and shopping list.

20 Lazy Dinners for When Your Brain Has Left the Building

Twenty low-effort recipes with prep times and dish counts.

20 Lazy Dinners Sorted by How Tired You Are

Find a dinner that matches your energy level tonight.